



If you are using a standard QWERTY keyboard—and most of us do—your keyboard design is over a century old. Keyboard design has stagnated over the last few years. However, some vendors have launched products that are wacky to say the least, and ergonomic as well. For instance, SafeType Inc launched a keyboard that they claim is designed as per scientific biomechanical principles and virtually eliminates the high-stress postures that contribute to Repetitive Stress Injury (RSI). This device looks

like a standard QWERTY keyboard that's been broken up into three equal pieces. The two outermost pieces are placed vertically, with keys on the outside, and a couple of mirrors placed alongside. The horizontal middle piece has the number keys.

Do Remember

■ The QWERTY keyboard layout was invented by Christopher Sholes in 1867. This layout is dominant even today. It was used on the Sholes & Glidden type-Writer, manufactured by E. Remington & Sons in 1874.



Buying Tips

✓ **AESTHETICS:** The keyboard needs to be soft and smooth to the touch. The pegs should be sturdy; many tend to break with the slightest jerk. The keys should be responsive. Try to fit in a wrist pad to lessen the strain on your wrists.

✓ **ERGONOMICS:** A "natural" keyboard ensures ease of typing. This ergonomic keyboard is split in the middle, offsetting the keys where the two hands lie. It does take some time to get used to it, especially since the arrow keys have been completely changed.

✓ **HOTKEYS:** Hotkeys let you open programs such as messengers, e-mail applications, or a Web browser, at the touch of a button. Opt for a keyboard that integrates a large number of hotkeys in the layout. Some keyboards might have a scroll button for added flexibility.

✓ **WATERPROOFING:** Some keyboards are waterproof. Water gets drained out via the pores at the bottom of the device.

✓ **WIRELESS CONNECTIVITY:** Opt for an RF wireless keyboard. Unlike infrared-powered

devices, RF wireless connectivity does not require the keyboard to be within line-of-sight. Make it a point to check the number of batteries required. Lastly, make a note of the maximum range at which the keyboard works.

✓ **Key spacing** is one important aspect that you should look out for before settling on a particular model. New keyboards are crammed with keys making it impossible to use the keyboard without fatigue.

✓ **Before you buy**, use the keyboard and try to get a feel of it, some keyboard look good but they might not suit your style of typing.

✓ **Mechanical keyboards** are still a better bet when it comes to durability, membrane keyboards wear out in two-three years.

✓ **Wireless keyboards** are good for clean and neat desk but be prepared for their higher running cost, since they require batteries to run.

✓ **Do not use rechargeable batteries** in wireless keyboards as they have a different rating that does not suit most electronics, if otherwise specified.

Ready Reckoner



You Need

A reasonably priced keyboard that offers touch typing

Look for

A membrane keyboard with 104 keys in the range of Rs 300-375.



You Need

Good ergonomics, style and comfort

Look for

Hotkeys, and an ergonomically engineered design



You Need

Comfort, security, ergonomics and good looks.

Look for

Advanced security features, trackball and wire free connectivity



■ Tomorrow's computer keyboard might be played more like an accordion than a piano, says a Cornell University ergonomist. This, he says, is because a prototype vertical split keyboard (VK) allows two to three times more typing movements to stay in safe, low-risk positions for carpal tunnel syndrome, compared with a traditional keyboard.

■ A good example of vertical keyboard is SafeType keyboard. This keyboard is designed to reduce the stress on your wrist by placing the keys in the vertical axis, rather than horizontal as with normal keyboard.

■ Microsoft has a series of keyboards specifically designed to reduce stress due to typing and they are much cheaper than solutions such as SafeType.

■ If you are new to typing, then probably you can learn on a "Dvorak" keyboard rather than "QWERT" type. The Dvorak is known to be user friendly and intuitive.